

DigiPick of the month

"Aha! A Backup!"



Last month's winner is
Soundarapandian

Madurai

Participate and win next month

Windows Vista

by Michael Meskers



Published by

WILEY-INDIA

WIN!

Send in your entry and you could win an exciting gift just by sharing an amusing picture with a tech angle to it. The picture should have been shot by you, and should not have been published anywhere earlier. E-mail your picture with the subject **"DigiPick"** and your postal address **on or before the 20th of this month** to **digipick@thinkdigit.com**. One prize-winning picture will be published each month.

entries, making him almost a celebrity.

Serin is officially called the most hated blogger in the world, and news has it that one reader paid Serin to answer personal questions, such as explaining why his wife dropped out of college. Someone even paid \$250 for the opportunity to vent at him for an hour about financial responsibility.

Ah, it's all good. This is the Internet, and we have our own idiosyncrasies, we're really a community, we have our own celebrities. We're one big happy family.

THERE'S CASH TO BE HAD

Of Webcams And Worship

We're supposing you've read earlier in this section about how Casey Serin, the loser-blogger, now makes his money. If you thought that was a rip-off, just read on.

Take this MySpace user for example, who claims to have 1,00,000 friends on his or her MySpace profile (S)he's selling the profile on eBay.

The winning bid hit \$2,125. Explanations, anyone?

Perhaps the buyer wanted a spam-list... but then those come at much lower prices. Perhaps it's out of an ego that says one should have a lot of friends—but then whatever happened to the Bard's "To thine own self be true"? Our best guess is that some kind of bet was happening, with two people slugging it out over who had the most friends.

Then, check out www.poip.co.il/english/main-english.htm. This is an Israeli start-up called POIP (Prayer Over Internet Protocol), and it sends prayers with the customer's voice to eight sacred sites in Jerusalem. So how does this work? Simple. From the site: "Your recorded prayers will gain access to your chosen holy site/s in Israel. It's only 3 easy steps away. Try it now and have your prayer heard today at the sight (sic) you choose for a cost of only \$7.00.

"We provide your soul unlimited access to holiness, Try it now!" "It's just \$10 and you get eternal life," POIP chairman Hanan Achsaf told *The Wall Street Journal*. "With the lottery, what do you get?

A piece of paper. This is much better value." True enough, come to think of it.

Is this the way ahead? We've heard of a Pakistani site that will sacrifice an animal for you at a holy site for money. No news on how that one is doing.

How long before you can do virtual *darshans*? No, wait. Isn't something like that already up? Google it.

OF FAIRIES AND FAT PEOPLE

The Zeitgeist Of The Times

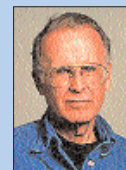
The Google Zeitgeist, as you might know, gives you a window on what the world is searching for. Here are some gems from the last updated country-wise Zeitgeist—April 2007. (No, this is not stale news—the Zeitgeist takes some weeks to get updated.)

In Afghanistan, there are no railways, which we learnt in school. We also thought there was no Internet there—ever been to an Afghan Web site? Surprise, surprise! There are Internet users in Afghanistan, though no-

People Who Changed Computing

John "HLL" Backus

An IBM team led by a man called John Backus created FORTRAN, the language that changed the way humans and computers



John "HLL" Backus

communicate. Prior to FORTRAN, programmers had to program in assembly code—time consuming, tedious, and difficult to debug. FORTRAN was so efficient that it reduced programming statements by a factor of 20!

After graduating from Columbia University, he joined the IBM computer centre in New York, where his job was to fix the Selective Sequence Electronic Calculator (SSEC) whenever it stopped running. The SSEC was one of IBM's early electronic computers; it had thousands of unreliable, electromechanical parts. Tired of the machine, Backus asked his superiors to allow him to head a research project to simplify programming. In 1953, IBM developed the first mass-produced computer that supported floating-point arithmetic and "core memory." It was called the 704; its features could reduce the operating time of the system, but for the lack of efficient computer programs they could not harness its true potential.

Backus outlined design of a programming language for the 704. Overcoming challenges, FORTRAN was developed, and became the most used programming system in the world.

Backus received the W. W. McDowell award for outstanding contributions in computing from the IEEE in 1967, and the ACM Turing award in 1977 for his contributions to the field of programming languages.